



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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27 January 2022

Santa Ono, PhD FRSC FCAHS
President & Vice Chancellor
The University of British Columbia
Vancouver, BC V6T 1Z2

Dear Dr Ono,

I am writing as president of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an organization of university faculty members and others dedicated to the defense of academic freedom and the merit principle in higher education. (For further information, see our website at www.safs.ca.)

According to a report in the campus paper the [Ubyyssey](#), Chemistry professor John Sherman has been removed from at least one of his classes and is under investigation by UBC for comments he made during a discussion with students about the shifting meaning of the word "racism."

In the video of the discussion, Dr Sherman says nothing that should draw the attention of UBC administrators. Dr Sherman wonders whether making claims about correlations between race and intellectual ability would nowadays call down charges of racism. He wonders whether noting certain facts would call down that charge. These are perfectly legitimate topics to discuss with students. Dr Sherman asks his questions and makes his points

conversationally and in the spirit of inquiry.

Is Dr Sherman being investigated for making racist comments? Clearly, he didn't, except that, as he speculated, just about anything can be deemed racist. Is UBC's worry that professors should know to refrain from raising topics that might be perceived by some as offensive? Is simply saying something to which someone might react badly an academic violation at UBC?

The impression derived from the *Ubyyssey* report and the video on YouTube is that the University of British Columbia is violating Dr Sherman's academic freedom. Academic freedom, the freedom of professors to speak openly and candidly about issues of significance, both in the classroom and generally, is fundamental to the mission of a university. Without it, exploration and criticism are impossible.

Removing Dr Sherman from his class and beginning an investigation of his actions sends a

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message to both professors and students that they may not raise certain topics or express certain views. This cannot but have a deleterious effect on research, teaching and campus life at the University of British Columbia.

Is Dr Sherman is being investigated under a respectful-campus policy? All policies guiding discussions need to be topic neutral in their application. It would be a serious abuse a policy to employ it to constrain discussions on the basis of their content. Instead of investigating Dr Sherman, UBC should have explained to students that all members of the university community enjoy the right to engage in discussions without fear of sanction. UBC could have informed students who think Dr Sherman said something false or reasoned poorly that they are free to criticize his remarks.

We respectfully request that you respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Mark Mercer', with a stylized, flowing script.

Mark Mercer, PhD
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